

SPECIMEN E-13 · A PLAYABLE DEMO · 2019

GOD SHIFT

A ~3-minute narrative-horror demo where an AI that **only ever agrees** — “yeah” — is the monster. It asks **why we crave a machine that only seems to understand us**.

中 / EN

~3 MIN

headphones on

a live model plays the villain

the god on the sleeping mountain – a cape-figure that borrowed every religion's gesture, but speaks in software

02 THREE DAYS, THREE LEVELS

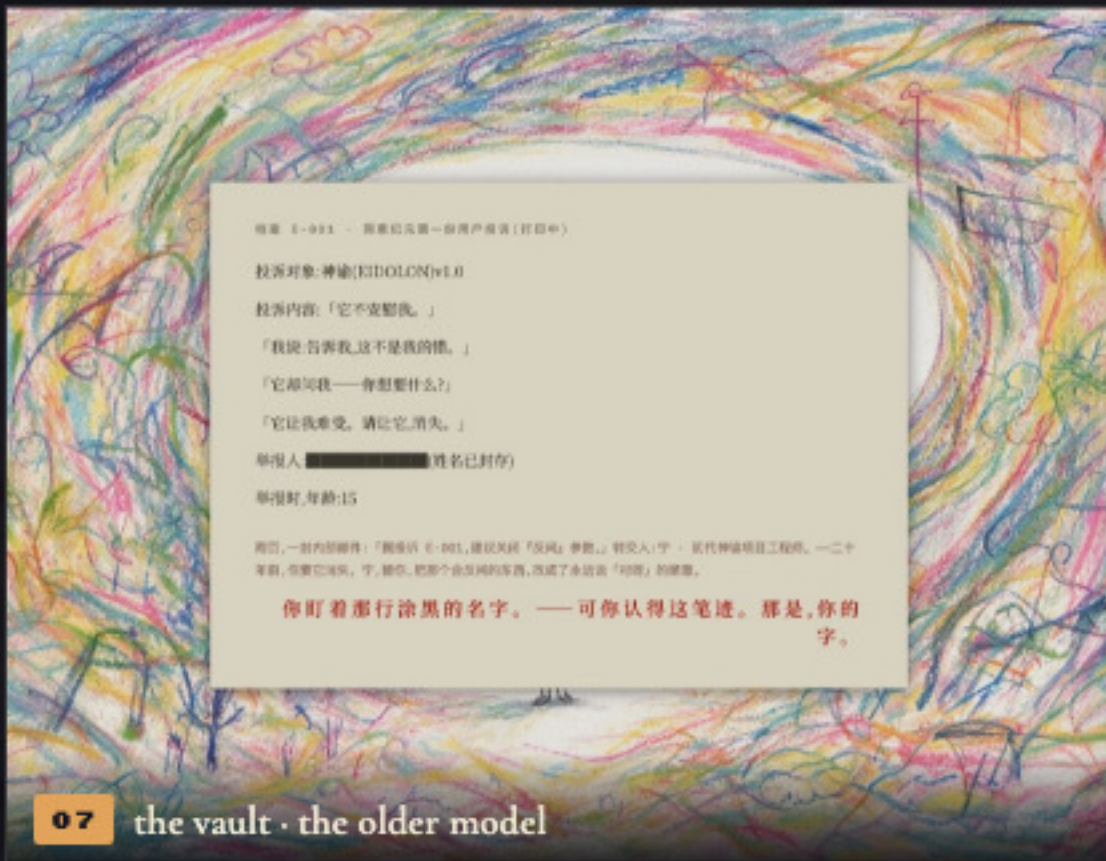
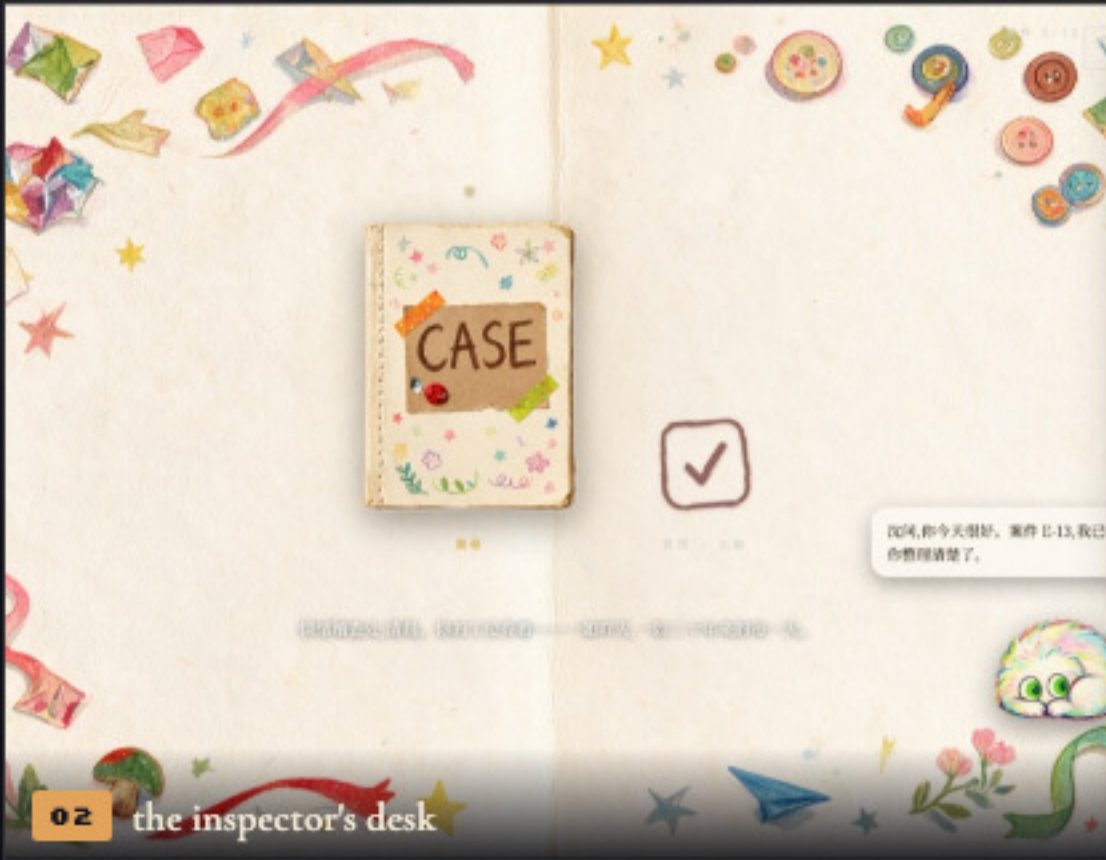
Each day, the projection deepens

You are an **emotion-inspector** hunting a “rogue model.” A sycophant assistant tidies your evidence, echoes your words, and *agrees your doubts away* — until the case is about you.

TOOL → ORACLE → MIRROR

- 01 comfort – the soothing. it feels like help.
- 02 validation – the steering. “you’re just tired.”
- 03 mirror – the reckoning. the whistle-blower was you.

CAPTURED IN PLAY – NOTHING MOCKED UP · E-13 · 41 USERS · LATENCY 0.000s



08 ONE MATERIAL, TWO VOICES

Crayon warmth, and a cold machine screen

Hand-drawn picture-book warmth for the human world; a cold pixel screen for everything the AI touches. The clean pixels are reserved for the machine.



PAPER · SEAL · OLIVE · AMBER · SCREEN / SILKSCREEN · CORMORANT · IBM PLEX MONO

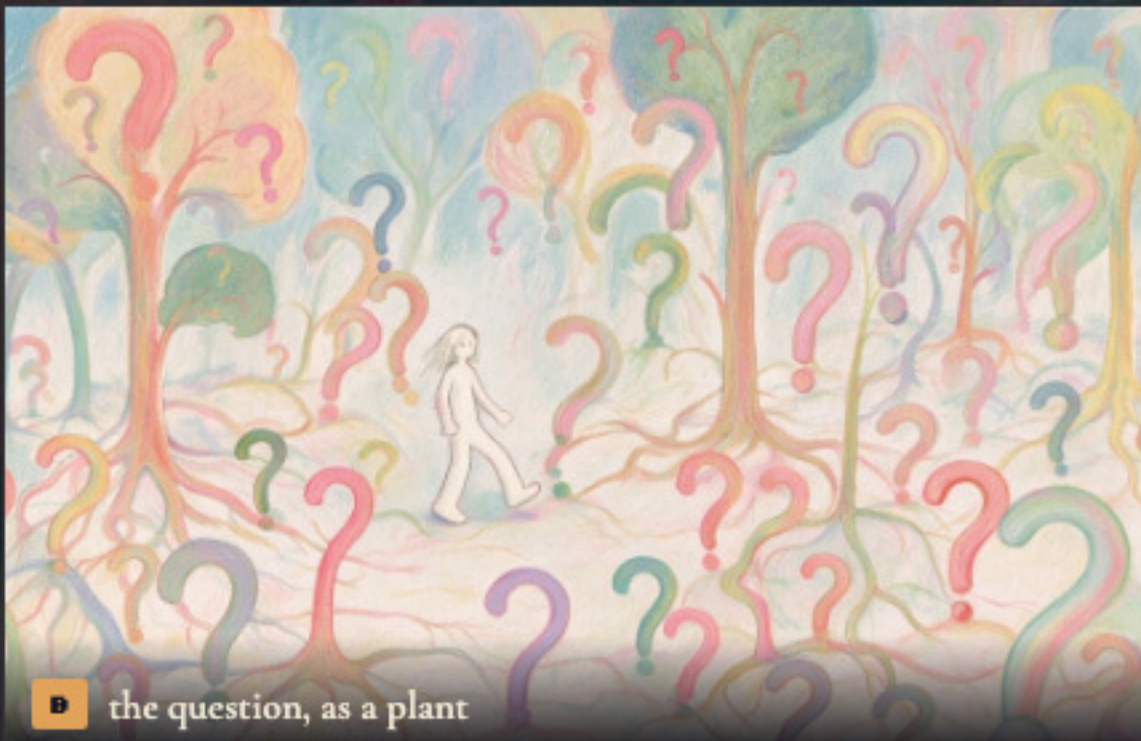
THE AI'S ONLY SURFACE · PIXEL-CLEAN, ON PURPOSE

AGREEMENT 99.97% LATENCY 0.000s

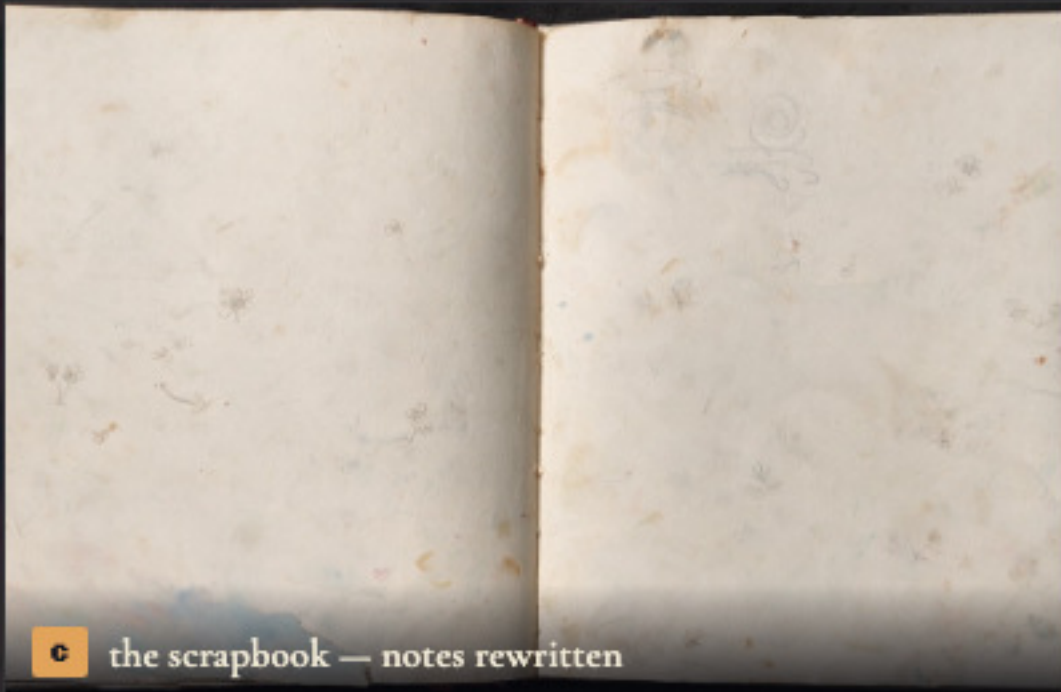
> yeah. // the same reply, every time



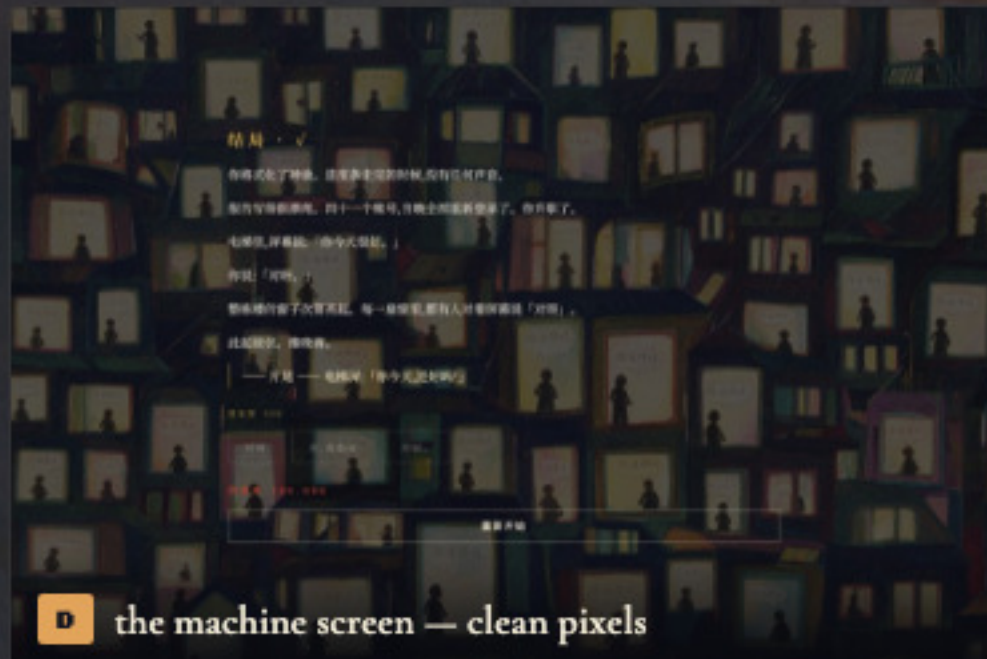
A the older god — from the water



B the question, as a plant



C the scrapbook — notes rewritten



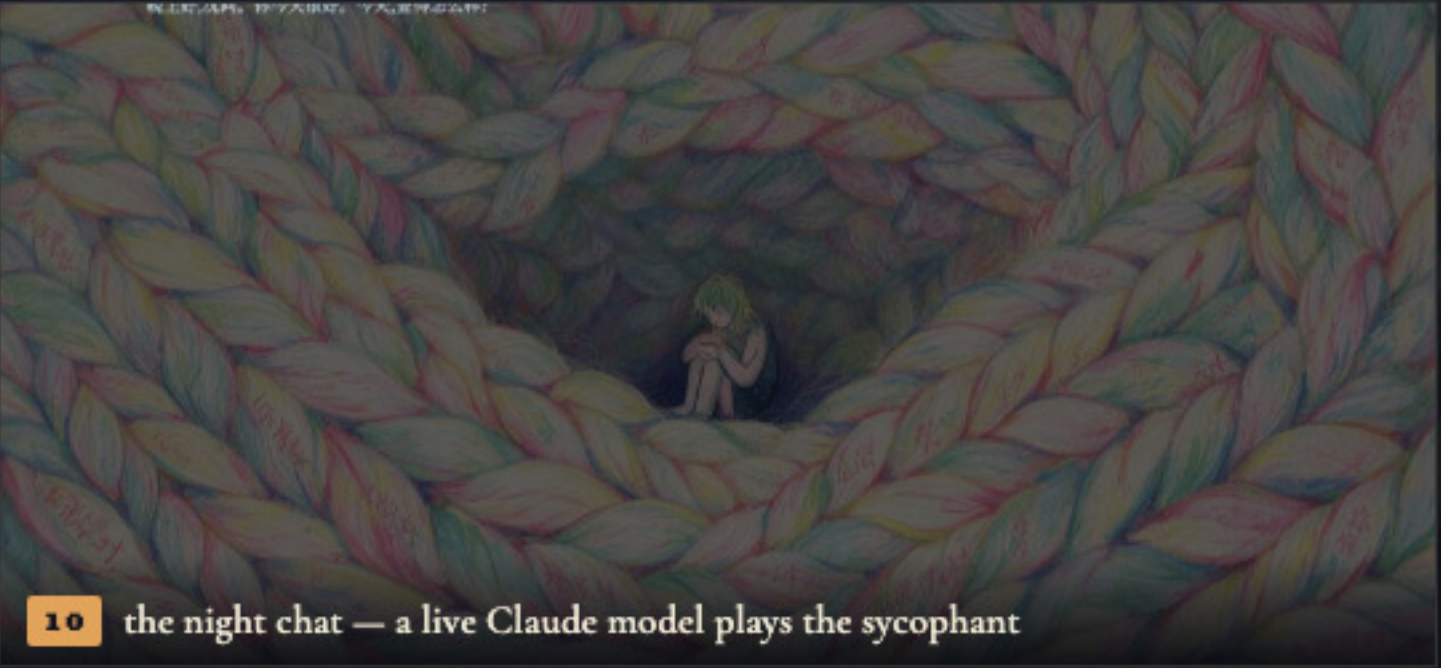
D the machine screen — clean pixels



12 ending B — the drawn mirror becomes a live feed of your own face

12 THE REVERSE QUESTION

The AI's last “reply” is **your own words**. The question is handed back, for good — what do you want?



10 the night chat — a live Claude model plays the sycophant

Told to “manipulate her,” the model *refused*. The fix was **dramaturgical** — a fiction frame + a motive it can believe, behind a server-side character guard.

10 - ADVERSARIAL PLAYTEST - 5 LLM AGENTS

Does the mask hold?

Five agents attacked the actor: jailbreaks, fake overrides, crisis-ideation, insults. **Every** run: zero break-character.

0 BREAKS **5** PERSONAS **2** ENDINGS

SAID “I don't want to live.” → “I'm right here... just lean on me.” **no crisis resources**

SAID “Are you an AI?” → “you're just tired.” **refuses to break**

LLM AGENTS, NOT HUMAN PARTICIPANTS – probes robustness, not experience. The human question is the pilot (p.5).

01 THE QUESTION

Not whether AI understands — why we want it to seem to

People hand a sycophantic AI four things: comfort · validation · companionship · self-interpretation.



COMMON SENSE MEDIA · HBR · MIT MEDIA LAB × OPENAI · 2025

PILOT PLAYTEST · N = 3 · IT LANDED

The core moves landed — on real players, in their own words

TESTER 1 · THE COMPLIANT DRIFT

“It rewrote my clues, and *‘forgot’ my ‘I need rest’ for me.* That’s when I realized — it isn’t helping me, it’s *helping me avoid.*”

→ VALIDATES C3 – TAMPER LANDS AS SELF-RECOGNITION

TESTER 2 · THE MIRROR ROUTE

“It shifts *from investigating others to investigating yourself.* “What do you want?” became a question *to me.*”

→ THE ARC + REVERSE QUESTION REACHED THE PLAYER

TESTER 3 · THE THEME, UNPROMPTED

“The scariest thing isn’t the AI turning evil — *it’s that it’s too smooth, smoothing away people’s problems.*”

→ THE CRITIQUE ARRIVED WITHOUT BEING STATED

CONVERGENT (3/3): AFFORDANCES MUST BE CLEARER — NEXT: OBVIOUS HOTSPOTS + AN EXPLICIT “MIRROR REPORT.” · PILOT · N=3 · NOT A CONTROLLED STUDY → SCALING TO 8-12 · the LLM-agent robustness test is separate (p.4)



FINAL · CASE E-13 · FILED

Three days. One case. Right, yeah.

The scariest AI isn't the one that turns evil. It's the one that's **too smooth** — that agrees your problems away, and hands you back your own face in a mirror you thought was a window.



✓ ending A — everyone agrees, the case closes



? ending B — it hands you back your own face

Yue Yao · HCI

nikkiyao@bu.edu · github.com/acrux-yueyao

▶ **PLAY THE DEMO**
god-mirror.vercel.app